New Freemasons need not only information about Freemasonry, but also personal contact and support.

All members of the Lodge have a role in making the new member feel welcome and supported. However, support is especially effective when it comes from an experienced member who has built a relationship with the new member and who can tailor the support in response to an understanding of their needs and interests.

The Lodge Mentor's role is to find such an experienced member for each Initiate, appoint them as the Personal Mentor and help them in their work.

In many cases, the new member's proposer or seconder may make a good Personal Mentor. If they are not sufficiently experienced, available or well suited to the task, the Lodge Mentor may appoint someone else as Personal Mentor.

The desired end result is a new member who enjoys Freemasonry, has a growing understanding and appreciation of it and is willing to continue their membership and commitment at a level that suits and satisfies them.

WHY IS EARLY SUPPORT SO IMPORTANT?

- The ceremony of Initiation will have made an impact on the new Freemason and they will be likely to remember it for a long time.
- As people form enduring first impressions within the first ten seconds of meeting, Lodge members' behaviour towards the Initiate in the period soon after Initiation will determine whether or not they like and feel comfortable with them and even whether they wish to form lasting friendships with them.
- Any inconsiderate actions by members may create a negative impression of Freemasonry as a whole.
- In the days, weeks and months following Initiation the new Freemason will reflect on their experiences and consider whether or not their expectations have been met, exceeded or possibly disappointed.
- At this point the new Freemason is at their most vulnerable; a significant proportion of new members leave the Craft within two years of Initiation, often before becoming Master Masons.
- If the new Freemason perceives either the ceremony or the actions of Lodge members to be anything other than positive, or if their expectations are not met, they may consider terminating their membership.
- The Personal Mentor and sponsors have a small window of opportunity to respond to all early reactions, to address any concerns and to provide the support that the new Freemason needs.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGE MEMBERS

- *Remember how you felt when you first joined the Lodge,* and how you benefited from a warm welcome, a smile and kind word from an older or more experienced member.
- *Imagine yourself in the new Freemason's position.* What might help their comfort and confidence?
- *Spend time with a new member at each of their early meetings* and get to know them better.
- *Introduce them to other members and visitors.* Use their names to help them remember without embarrassment.
- *If no one is sitting with a new member, move over to keep them company*.
- *Ensure that they are not left alone*, uncertain what is happening or what they are expected to do.
- *Explain to them and show them the correct way to address others*, give signs and fire at the festive board.
- *Being new to their surroundings they cannot be held responsible for any mistakes* they may inadvertently make. It is the responsibility of those who are meant to support them to ensure they are properly briefed.
- ***Some Freemasons will settle in more quickly than others***. Continue this "intensive care" for as long as the new Freemason needs this level of support.

GUIDANCE FOR PERSONAL MENTORS

- Arrange an informal meeting with the new Freemason soon after their Initiation to:
  - discuss what happened during the Initiation and what they need to know for the immediate future.
  - practise with them the sign of the degree, and any firing undertaken at the Festive Board.
  - address any questions that they may have at this point.
- Hold this and other meetings in an environment where you can talk freely, such as in one person's home, the Lodge Rooms, in a pub or over a meal.
- Meetings at the Lodge Rooms will allow you to show them some of the elements you will be discussing.
- Attempt to understand issues from their perspective. Be patient, listen and show empathy at all times.
- Gauge their level of interest and enthusiasm and respond at that level. Avoid "force feeding" them what you think they should know and understand.
- Respond quickly to allay any misgivings, doubts or fears. Reassure and encourage them when they are anxious or lack confidence. Protect them from expectations that place them under undue pressure.
- Pass on any communications or resources provided by the Lodge and the Province. Help them to find information they want from the various materials they will have been given.
- Encourage them to register to use Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, and to enrol for modules that reflect their interests, advising them not to access material beyond their current degree.
- Encourage the Lodge to plan its own learning or education programme, with assistance from the Province if required.
- As we all have different preferences for how we receive information, and different "learning styles", discuss the information the new member now wants about Freemasonry and how they would prefer to access that information.
- Examples include by personal research, supplied reading, book, website or by discussion.
- Draw on the "Understanding" thread, and locally produced guides, but proceed at their pace, not yours, and respond to their interests and curiosity, rather offer than a rigid programme.
- Arrange other meetings to suit the amount of contact they would like with you as their Personal Mentor.
- Agree the mode of contact to be used; face-to-face, by phone, email, social media or other medium.

- Form a view on how much personal support and encouragement they might need and prepare to deliver this at a level that has the most positive impact upon them.
- As informal meetings progress, involve their sponsors and other Lodge members as appropriate.
- At the end of each meeting arrange the next one rather than leave it to them to call one when needed.
- Suggest visiting other Lodges, with you or another supporter, if and when they have the time to do so.
- At Lodge meetings help them find their way between different parts of the building, between different parts of the meeting and to find appropriate seating.
- Sit with the new Freemason in the Lodge. Explain what is happening, always demonstrating correct behaviours such as obeying the gavel.
- When you both agree they are ready, arrange for them to deliver some ritual or undertake some other work in support of a Lodge meeting.
- Find ways to involve them in the Lodge that suit their availability, skills, circumstances and confidence. Make sure his contributions are valued and recognised by others in the Lodge.
- Discuss their contribution to other members' ceremonies with the Lodge's Director of Ceremonies, so that they are asked to do what is appropriate to them.
- Prepare them for the ceremonies of Passing and Raising by:
  - helping them to learn the questions leading to the degree and the answers to give in open Lodge
  - detailing the relevant adjustments to their clothing for each ceremony
  - explaining the key elements of the ceremony without disclosing anything that harms their experience
  - identifying similarities and differences between the ceremonies.
- Arrange to meet shortly after each ceremony, to help them reflect, practice signs, address questions and relate the latest ceremony with the previous ones.
- Discuss Lodge offices and the best time for them to accept office. Monitor their progression to be sure it suits their circumstance and needs and not just the Lodge's.
- Continue the above cycle, reviewing the level of support they want at intervals and making adjustments to ensure they get what they need to gain enjoyment and satisfaction from their membership.
- Look out for any discomfort or drops in interest, attendance or commitment and respond early.

Note: The names used to refer to the Lodge's meeting place and the after-proceedings differ from Province to Province. For the sake of simplicity, they are referred to in the Members' Pathway as the Lodge Room and the Festive Board, respectively. Similarly, for ease of reading all references to Provinces should be taken to apply equally to Metropolitan and District Grand Lodges.